students marched to the local party office, causing damage to furniture and smashing windows. In the ensuing brawl, one student protestor was stabbed. Several hundred students gathered and marched to the teashop location where the initial trouble originated. Soldiers and police raided the RIT campus, escalating the already high level of tension.

Put into the context of worsening economic conditions, this protest and response initiated the most significant upheaval in Burma in the independence period. A key military leader, Sein Lwin, head of the notorious Lon Htein (riot police), acted in an overly aggressive fashion, which heightened tensions. Once the protesters arrived at the teashop, the Lon Htein attacked them with hoses, clubs, teargas, and firearms. A student by the name of Maung Phone Maw was killed in the clash. Over the next two days, protests increased as students from Rangoon Arts and Sciences University (RASU) and other local schools collaborated on staging rallies and protests. The movement was demanding the resignation of Ne Win along with steps toward multiparty democracy.

On March 16, the students marched to the now infamous White Bridge, an embankment along the western shore of Inya Lake between RIT and the RASU. The Lon Htein blocked the students. Scores were killed and many were beaten to death and several drowned in the lake. Women were sexually abused in a carnage that lasted approximately one hour. The authorities quickly disposed of the bodies and attempted to clean the area of the bloody mess. The following day, more arrests occurred at the RASU campus, as protesters demanded the government conduct an inquiry into the violence in recent days. The police arrested over 1,000 students, sending them to the infamous Insein jail. On Bloody Friday, March 18, students as well as ordinary citizens marched and rioted in route to the Sule pagoda in central Rangoon. So many arrests occurred that police had to ship detainees off to jails away from the capital. In one especially horrific incident, 41 students suffocated while being held in a police paddy wagon. The vehicle was parked for several hours in route to a jail transfer. The authorities closed the universities, sending students home and leading to the subsiding of the upheaval. Ultimately, the protesters lacked leadership and a coherent strategy. Calm returned to the capital as Ne Win departed for his usual vacation trip to Europe.